

CHAPTER 42 — The Second Decoy

Friday began with five people knowing five different things.

That was the point.

Jackie knew when they were preparing to move her.

Voss knew one old contractor channel that still answered.

Vale knew one vehicle supplier that had appeared around recent movements.

Elias knew two places he could take Zoe if everything went wrong.

Zoe knew what Cain still cared enough about to look at.

Nobody knew all of it.

Not even Zoe.

She hated that most.

They sat in a roadside café outside Ludlow with a laminated menu between them and Zoe's notebook open beside a plate of chips.

It was nine in the morning.

Elias looked at the chips.

"You know they serve breakfast."

"This is breakfast."

"It is chips."

"Breakfast chips."

He gave up.

Small victory.

At the top of the page Zoe had written:

SECOND DECOY

Beneath it:

JACKIE IS NOT BAIT.

Then:

NOBODY GETS EVERYTHING.

She left the page alone.

No circles.

No arrows.

No pretending the plan became safer because she could draw it neatly.

The first decoy had failed for one simple reason.

Jackie had carried the whole real route in her head.

Cain had found Jackie.

Then he had found the thing she loved enough to break for.

Her siblings.

This time there would be no one person to break.

Jackie knew timing.

Voss knew his piece.

Vale knew hers.

Elias knew the fallback.

Zoe knew the signal.

None of them could surrender what they did not have.

Elias pointed at the notebook.

"You still dislike this."

"I dislike not knowing things."

"Yes."

"I particularly dislike plans where I designed the not-knowing."

"That seems fair."

She ate another chip.

"What happens if Jackie moves early?"

"We adapt."

"What happens if Voss gets nothing?"

"We adapt."

"Vale?"

"Same."

"If Cain ignores me?"

"Then Jackie still moves."

Zoe nodded.

That mattered.

The plan did not require Cain to behave perfectly.

It only needed to make his world slightly less certain.

Her phone vibrated.

Nine twenty-eight.

Jackie.

Shift changed early. Bags downstairs. One driver I know, one I don't.
Cain not here. Legal woman here. Move likely before lunch.

Zoe read it twice.

The legal woman again.

Same person Jackie had seen at more than one property. That meant the move was not just a car. Paperwork was moving too. Authority. Or something pretending to be authority. A second message arrived. They took my shoes from hall. New coat on chair. Move definitely. Zoe

stared at the last part. New coat. Not hers. Good. No disguise. No pretending to

be Zoe. Jackie would leave as Jackie. The decoy existed somewhere else. Elias said: "Nothing back unless she asks." Zoe nodded. Jackie already knew what they needed. Timing. Not heroics. Not registration plates if obtaining one meant staring too long. Not names she had to steal.

Not a location she could not safely establish.

Just:

I am moving.

Zoe did not need more.

* * *

At nine forty, Voss unfolded a piece of paper on the desk in the lock-up.

One instruction.

Use old Meridian contractor callback. Ask whether a restricted recovery team is available at 13:00. No location.

Vale sat opposite him.

"That's yours?"

"Yes."

"What did I get?"

"Not your part."

She smiled.

"Still annoying."

"Good."

Voss used a number he had not called in years.

The line answered.

Different company wording.

Same procedural tone.

"Reference?"

"Legacy protected work."

"Client?"

Voss hesitated half a second. "AC019."

Silence. The code still meant something. Not necessarily the same thing it once had. Enough. "Location?"

"Not issued."

"Time?"

"Thirteen hundred."

"Recovery or transfer?"

"Recovery."

Another pause. "We don't have active instruction."

"Then note availability."

"Who are you?"

Voss gave his surname. That changed the voice on the other end.

"You're not active."

"No."

"Who told you to call?"

"No one."

"Then why are you calling?"

Voss looked at Vale.

"Because somebody may need a team at one."

He ended the call.

Vale waited.

"That was it?"

"Yes."

"What did we achieve?"

"Maybe nothing."

"And if not nothing?"

"Someone asks why an old contractor thinks something is happening at one."

"Zoe?"

"Unknown."

"Jackie?"

"Unknown."

"Very informative."

"Uncertainty is the information."

Vale sighed.

"You sound like her."

Voss wrote down the time.

09:43.

Then stopped.

No second call.

No fishing.

No team.

His part was done.

* * *

Vale waited eleven minutes before touching hers.

The vehicle company was ordinary.

That mattered.

It had supplied anonymous hire vehicles on old jobs, but ordinary companies supplied ordinary vehicles to people who later did bad things with them.

Vale called and attempted a same-day booking.

White Transit.

Two hours.

Old contractor account.

The clerk checked.

“That account is closed.”

“Thought it might be.”

“Do you have another?”

“No.”

“Then I can’t make the booking.”

“Fine.”

Vale paused.

“Can you tell me whether anything is already reserved against the old client?”

“No.”

Good answer.

Normal answer. She thanked the clerk and ended the call. Nothing happened. Ten minutes. Twenty. Then the old contractor portal changed. A line appeared.

TRANSIT — RESERVED — 11:45

Client hidden. Pickup branch not far from the region Jackie had been moved through. Vale stared at it. She had not booked the van. Maybe

somebody else had. Maybe it had nothing to do with her call. Maybe the timing mattered. Maybe it did not. She photographed the screen. Sent one line:

VEHICLE MOVEMENT POSSIBLE 11:45. NO CAUSATION.

Then closed the portal. No following it. No driving to the branch. No trying to discover who had made the booking.

Her piece was done too.

* * *

Zoe's part was harder.

Cain needed to see something that made him look away from Jackie.

Not a girl.

Not another coat.

Not a fake location full of people waiting to trap him.

Information.

Something real enough that Cain could not dismiss it.

Something incomplete enough that he had to make his own decision about what it meant.

The answer was already in the archive.

Her placement reference.

P06-11803.

Zoe hated using it.

Because it was hers.

Because it belonged to the room.

Helen.

Brian.

The glass.

That was also why Cain would care.

She wrote:

**P06-11803 / SOURCE AUTHORITY CONTRADICTION
CONFIRMED.**

ORIGINAL PRESENTATION SITE. 13:00.

Elias read it.

Then read it again.

"You're not claiming evidence is there."

"No."

"You're not claiming anyone will be there."

"No."

"You're giving him a real contradiction and a real place already connected to it."

"Yes."

"And letting him decide what thirteen hundred means."

Zoe looked at him.

"That is the idea."

"Good."

The old family-assessment centre was closed.

No children.

No current staff waiting inside.

Nobody had to stand there pretending to be Zoe.

If Cain ignored the message, nothing happened there.

If he acted on it, he chose to.

Zoe looked at the wording again.

No fake documents.

No invented cache.

No fictional witness.

Just a true case reference.

A true authority contradiction.

A true historic site.

And a time.

The message went through a dormant legal-query route already known to forward restricted alerts.

Deliberately visible.

At ten forty, Zoe sent it.

Then Elias closed the notebook.

"One more thing before we move."

"What?"

"The fallback."

She looked at him.

"There are two?"

"Yes."

"You know both."

"Yes."

"I know neither."

"Currently."

She narrowed her eyes.

"Is that you deciding, or me deciding?"

"Your decision."

Better.

He continued.

"If the signal gets connected to us, there is less to extract from you if you don't know which place I choose until we need it. But if you want both addresses now, you get both addresses now."

Zoe thought.

She hated the answer she was about to give.

"Do I get to change my mind?"

"Yes."

"If we move somewhere and I don't like it?"

"We leave."

"If I tell you I want the address before we arrive?"

"You get it."

She sighed.

"Then don't tell me yet."

Elias nodded.

That was all.

No congratulations.

No pretending she had become wise.

Zoe pointed at him.

"I still hate it."

"Expected."

"Agency is irritating."

"Often."

"Don't enjoy that."

"I don't."

"You do internally." "Unproven." Some things survived. Good. They left. Not towards the observation centre. Away.

* * *

Cain received the message at ten forty-seven. Restricted legal called him. "Possible P06 exposure." He stood before the woman finished. "What exposure?" She read the message.

P06-11803.

Source authority contradiction. Original presentation site. Thirteen hundred. Cain said nothing. He knew the site. Old Westmere family-assessment centre. Observation rooms. Recipient presentations.

One-way glass.

It should have been dead history.

The kind of location nobody revisited because too many things could be reconstructed if they did.

"Who sent it?"

"Unknown."

"Who has seen it?"

"Legal triage."

"Mac?"

"Not through us."

Cain looked at the time.

Ten forty-seven.

The message could mean nothing.

It could mean someone had linked P06 to the site.

It could mean documents.

A witness.

A meeting.

An attempt to verify who still reacted.

That last possibility should have slowed him.

It did not.

“Do not forward it.”

The woman hesitated.

“Cain—”

“Hold it.”

“What are you doing?” “Checking.” He ended the call. He knew Jackie’s relocation was expected after the compromised phone. He did not know she was already preparing to leave. Not yet. He picked up his coat.

* * *

At ten fifty-eight, Jackie walked out of the house. No hood pulled low. No borrowed identity. No Zoe coat. Her own clothes. A new jacket somebody else had chosen. The legal woman carried a folder. The familiar driver opened the rear door of a dark people carrier. Jackie looked once down the street. Blue recycling bins. Woman with a buggy. White van parked half on the pavement. Nothing dramatic. No Voss. No Vale.

No Elias. Good. Nobody had come for her. She got in. The legal woman sat beside her. The vehicle pulled away. Jackie started counting. Left. Right. Roundabout. Long straight. Lights. Railway crossing. Not because she thought she could build a map from it later. Counting gave fear a job. The legal woman noticed. “You can stop doing that.”

“Doing what?”

“Counting.”

Jackie looked offended. “Maybe I’m counting sheep.”

“It’s ten in the morning.”

"Progressive sheep."

The woman looked away. Jackie watched the folder instead. Not enough to lean. Not enough to get caught. Two tabs were visible.

RISK / INTERNAL CONTACT

MOVE AUTHORITY

She left them alone. Knowing when not to look was useful too. The woman's phone vibrated. "Yes." Pause. "No. We're already mobile." Another pause. Her expression changed. "That isn't our route." Jackie stared through the window. "Who sent it?" Pause. "P06?" Jackie kept her face blank. The woman listened. Then:

"Cain knows?" Pause. "Fine." She ended the call. The driver checked the mirror. "What?" "Nothing. Stay on route." Jackie looked outside. Something had happened. She did not know what. Good. That was the point.

* * *

At eleven twelve, Voss's old phone lit.

AVAILABILITY REQUIRED — POSSIBLE 13:00 LEGACY RECOVERY

Vale leaned over. "They answered." "They responded." "That is answering." Voss ignored her. A second message followed.

STANDBY ONLY. DO NOT CONTACT CLIENT.

Voss photographed the screen.

Powered the phone down.

No reply.

No attempt to discover location.

No attempt to assemble anybody.

Done.

For once, knowing when to stop felt more professional than knowing how to continue.

* * *

At eleven twenty, Vale's portal changed again.

The Transit reservation moved branches.

Closer to the old presentation-site area.

She looked at the map.

Closed it.

Her message was equally brief.

**VEHICLE RESERVATION SHIFTED TOWARD
PRESENTATION-SITE**

AREA. NO CAUSATION CLAIMED.

Then she stopped too.

* * *

At eleven thirty-eight, Margaret called Mac.

"Cain is moving."

Mac stood.

"How do you know?"

"Old contractor standby appeared. Vehicle reservation changed. Both after a P06 message."

"What message?"

Margaret read it.

Mac swore.

"That is bait."

"Possibly."

"Who sent it?"

"Unknown."

"Cain told you?"

"No."

Of course he had not.

"Jackie?"

"Already mobile."

Mac went still.

"When?"

"About forty minutes ago."

Two separate facts collided.

Cain had turned his attention towards P06.

Jackie was being moved.

Contractor channels had woken.

Vehicle channels had moved.

Someone had introduced uncertainty into different compartments at the same time.

Mac saw the outline.

Not enough to prove who.

Enough to recognise the method.

"The first one used a person," he said.

Margaret was quiet.

"This one doesn't."

"You think Zoe."

"I think somebody learned."

"Not the same thing."

Mac sat again.

No admiration.

No pride.

Only the uncomfortable recognition that the system was now being used against its own habits.

"Where is Jackie going?"

Margaret checked.

"Transfer destination changed once already."

"Who authorised?"

"Restricted chain."

"Cain?"

"Not directly."

Mac stared at nothing.

That used to be reassuring.

Now it sounded dangerous.

* * *

Jackie knew the route had changed because the driver objected.

"Instruction was north." The legal woman said: "Instruction changed."
"By who?" "Central." "That isn't a person." "Drive." They left the dual
carriageway. More buildings. More traffic. The legal woman made
another call. "No, she's with us." Pause. "No." Another pause. "What

site?" Jackie looked at her hands. The woman listened. "That's
unrelated." Pause. "Fine." She ended the call. The driver glanced
across.

"What?"

"They want authority verified before transfer."

"To where?"

"Not our concern."

Transfer. So this car had never been the final destination. Jackie filed that away. The move was no longer smooth. People were asking one another questions. That was probably what Zoe wanted. Not a rescue car roaring alongside them. Not Elias appearing with a gun. Hesitation. Jackie almost smiled. The legal woman noticed. "What?"

"Nothing."

"You're smiling."

"I remembered something."

"What?"

"Purple penguin."

The woman stared. Jackie smiled properly.

"Never mind."

* * *

At twelve oh three, they entered the rear yard of a small office building. A solicitor's plaque faced the street. The legal woman went inside. Jackie stayed in the vehicle with the driver. Five minutes. Seven. Nine. The driver's phone rang. "Yeah."

Pause. "What do you mean, hold?"

He looked at Jackie in the mirror. "She's in the vehicle."

Pause. "No, legal went inside."

Another pause. "Fine."

He hung up. Jackie watched the yard. Camera over the gate. One side door.

No pedestrians.

She did not try anything.

The driver looked back.

"You alright?"

"Brilliant."

He shrugged.

"Just asking."

Maybe he knew what the move really was.

Maybe he knew only that he had been paid to drive a teenager under some kind of restricted case arrangement.

Jackie could not tell.

So she did not decide for him.

* * *

At twelve thirteen, a separate problem began elsewhere.

Westmere compliance received an internal alert that someone had queried archived access connected to the old presentation centre.

Elaine Foster recognised the site immediately.

Not because of Zoe.

Because the centre had already appeared around the restricted cases North Vale was asking about.

She opened the old booking system.

After-hours presentations.

Recipient references.

No child names visible in the first layer.

Elaine froze the records.

Then called North Vale.

Nobody had told her to preserve them.

That was simply what she did when a current unknown query touched material already under concern.

Another record now existed because somebody had reacted.

* * *

At twelve twenty, Elias pulled behind a garden centre.

Zoe looked outside.

"This is one of the fallbacks?"

"No."

"Then what is it?"

"Wait point."

"You really enjoy naming normal things."

"Useful."

He switched on the one-use receiver.

Messages arrived.

Voss:

CONTRACTOR STANDBY CREATED FOR 13:00.

Vale:

VEHICLE RESERVATION SHIFTED TOWARD PRESENTATION SITE.

NO CAUSATION.

Priya:

WESTMERE PRESERVING OLD PRESENTATION-SITE LOGS AFTER

CURRENT QUERY.

Nothing from Jackie.

Zoe stared at the screen. "No Jackie."

"She said she expected to lose the phone."

"I know."

"Movement started."

"I know."

"We planned for silence."

"I know."

Every true sentence made waiting worse. "What if they change everything?"

"They might."

"What if she needs us?"

"We don't know."

Zoe looked at him. "That is horrible."

"Yes."

He did not tell her it would be fine. Good. She reached for the notebook. Stopped. Closed it again. There was nothing useful she could write. Jackie had her piece.

Voss and Vale had stopped after theirs. Now Zoe had to do the part she hated most. Nothing.

* * *

At twelve thirty-one, Cain arrived at the old family-assessment centre. One man with him. The reserved Transit arrived a few minutes later. Standby. No Zoe. No Voss. No Vale. No witness waiting by the gate. No secret archive being unloaded. Just a dead building behind fencing. Cain knew before he stepped out of the saloon. Bait. Not necessarily because the message was false. The case number was real. The authority contradiction was real. The site was real. The time had been enough. He had supplied the rest himself. Cain called restricted legal.

"Where is Jackie?"

"Mobile."

"Destination?"

"Transfer hold."

He went still.

"Why?"

"Authority verification after the P06 alert."

"I ordered no hold."

"No. Legal requested verification."

Cain looked through the locked gate.

"Resume."

"To which approved destination?"

He opened his mouth.

Stopped.

The destination had changed after the phone breach.

Two fallback properties existed.

Which one had completed approval?

"Send me the authority."

"Not over open line."

His jaw tightened.

The same need-to-know rules that had protected the route for years were now slowing him.

"Call me back."

He ended the call.

Across the fence, the old centre showed him nothing.

* * *

At twelve forty-five, the legal woman returned to Jackie's vehicle. Angry now. Not panicked. The driver opened his door. "Where?"

"Not yet."

"What?"

"Authority mismatch."

Jackie looked at the window. Those words again. The legal woman climbed in. "Take us somewhere public."

The driver frowned. "What?"

"Public waiting. Services. Station. I don't care."

They pulled out. Jackie kept her face neutral. She did not know whether this was good. Good had become a dangerous word.

* * *

At twelve fifty-eight, they entered a motorway service area.

Busy. Families. Lorries. Staff in bright uniforms. A school coach two bays away. The legal woman told Jackie: "Stay in the vehicle." Jackie nodded. The driver and the woman got out and began arguing near the bonnet. Jackie watched them. The rear lock pin was up. Door unlocked. She could open it. Ten feet to the pavement. Twenty to the building. Run inside. Shout. Find security. Call police. Maybe she could get herself out of the car. That did not get her brother and sisters out of anything. It did not tell her whether Cain's people still knew where they were. It did not tell her who would reach her first after she ran.

And it turned everything after the door into another guess. Jackie stayed seated. The choice hurt more because the door was open. Then she saw the coach. Children in uniform. Teacher counting them. Backpacks. Noise. For half a second her brain offered the old solution. Disappear into them. Confusion. Wrong child. Wrong direction. Zoe's coat. The first

decoy. No. Jackie stayed where she was. She was not turning another group of children into cover. Not again.

* * *

At one oh four, Mac stopped trying to understand the whole picture. He called Margaret. "I need the current duty safeguarding contact."

Silence. "For what?"

"Jackie."

"You understand what that means."

"Yes."

"If you make a current disclosure, you do not control what they do next."

"I know."

"You may be asked to identify yourself."

"I know."

"Cain will know somebody opened the route."

"I know."

Margaret gave him the contact. Nothing more. Mac called. He did not give them a command. He could not. He gave them information. A child was currently being moved under disputed authority. There was an active concern about the legitimacy of the transfer. The paperwork chain had produced an authority mismatch. The child had recently been subject to restricted communications. There was reason to believe she had been held across multiple properties. The current movement needed independent safeguarding verification.

The woman on the other end stopped him twice. Asked questions. Some he could answer. Some he could not. Then: "Where is she now?"

Mac gave the service area. "Who is with her?"

He described the legal administrator and vehicle. "Are you the child's guardian?"

"No."

"Social worker?"

"No."

"Legal representative?"

"No."

“What is your relationship to this case?”

Mac looked through his office window. There were a dozen answers. None he wanted recorded. “Someone who should have spoken sooner.”

Silence. The woman did not accept that as sufficient. Good.

She asked for his full name. He gave it. Then she told him what would happen. Their decision. Their officers. Their record. Mac would receive no destination afterward. No staff details. No child address. He agreed. Then hung up. For the first time, opening a route meant losing control of it.

* * *

The legal woman’s phone rang six minutes later. She answered beside the bonnet. Jackie watched through the window. The woman’s expression changed. Not fear. Calculation. Then irritation. She turned away from the driver. Listened. Argued.

Looked at Jackie.

The driver said something.

The woman held up one finger.

Kept listening.

Finally:

“Yes.”

Pause.

“I understand.”

She ended the call.

The driver asked:

“What?”

The woman looked at the vehicle.

“Independent safeguarding team is attending.”

His face changed.

"Who requested that?"

"Does it matter?"

"Yes."

"Not anymore."

"Cain said—"

"I know what Cain said."

She looked towards Jackie.

Then back to the driver.

"The authority on this transfer is disputed. I'm not moving her again under it."

The driver stared.

"So what are we doing?"

"We wait."

That was her choice.

Not Mac's.

Not Cain's.

Hers.

Jackie did not know whether the woman had grown a conscience in the last ten minutes.

Probably not.

Maybe she had simply decided she would rather sign a real handover than become the person recorded as moving a child after somebody formally disputed the authority.

Jackie did not care what made the difference.

Only that the difference existed.

* * *

Two women arrived twenty-one minutes later.

No dramatic entrance.

No police convoy.

One council vehicle.

Identification shown to the legal woman first.

Then Jackie.

The older of the two opened the rear door.

"Jackie?"

Jackie stayed seated.

"Maybe."

The woman almost smiled.

"My name is Sarah. This is Leanne. We're from the local authority safeguarding team."

"Prove it."

The driver looked embarrassed.

The legal woman did not.

Sarah actually laughed.

One short surprised laugh.

Then stopped when she saw Jackie's face.

"Fair."

She produced identification.

Jackie examined it.

Front.

Back.

Photograph.

Organisation.

Then:

“Phone number.”

Sarah gave her the public office number.

Jackie looked at Leanne.

“Call it.”

Leanne did.

The office answered.

Sarah waited.

Nobody told Jackie she was being difficult.

Nobody told her she had to trust them.

When Jackie finally got out of the car, she did it because enough things matched.

Not because somebody opened the door.

The legal woman signed the handover.

Her hand hesitated over the paper.

Then completed it.

Jackie watched.

“Where am I going?”

Sarah said:

“Somewhere temporary while we establish what is happening.”

“Can I have a solicitor?”

"Yes."

"Now?"

"We can start arranging one now."

"Can I contact my friend?"

"We need to talk about safe contact first."

Jackie's shoulders tightened.

Sarah noticed.

"That was not a no."

Better.

Jackie nodded once.

"Okay."

She hated the word.

Still said it.

* * *

At one seventeen, Zoe's receiver vibrated.

Priya.

**UNCONFIRMED: CURRENT SAFEGUARDING HANDOVER
INITIATED FOR JACKIE. SHADOW TRANSFER APPEARS
CANCELLED. DO NOT MOVE.**

Zoe went back over the line.

"Current safeguarding."

"Unconfirmed."

"Still."

"Yes."

"Who caused it?"

“Unknown.”

“Mac?”

“Possible.”

“Westmere?”

“Possible.”

“North Vale?”

“Possible.”

She glared at him.

“You are enjoying this.”

“No.”

“You have three words.”

“Efficient.”

Then Voss:

LEGACY CONTRACTOR STANDBY CANCELLED 13:16.

Vale:

TRANSIT RESERVATION CANCELLED.

Zoe stared at the receiver.

Still nothing from Jackie.

Then a new number appeared through Priya’s relay.

A message.

I am in a room with two women who gave me water and asked if I want a solicitor. One has council ID. I asked her to prove it. She laughed. Then proved it.

Zoe covered her mouth.

Elias said nothing.

She kept reading.

They can check my brother and sisters through protected contact.
They will not tell me where they are unless it is safe. I said okay.

Then:

Do not come here yet.

Zoe laughed.

Then cried.

Then got annoyed because she was doing both.

She wiped her face.

"That's her."

"Yes."

No likely.

No probability.

Jackie was communicating from a documented current process with
adults who had accepted being challenged.

Not home.

Not finished.

Not magically safe forever.

But out of Cain's moving chain.

Zoe looked at Elias.

"We didn't rescue her."

"No."

"The decoy didn't tell them where to take her."

"No."

"We just made everything wobble."

“Enough.”

She thought about that.

Enough.

For somebody else to ask a question.

Enough for the legal woman to refuse another movement.

Enough for a current safeguarding team to arrive.

Not control.

Space.

Zoe understood the difference without writing it down.

* * *

At two, Cain learned Jackie had been handed over. Not escaped. That would have been easier. Current authority. Logged. Two local-authority workers. Solicitor offered. The legal administrator had signed the transfer. Cain listened to the report. “Who authorised it?” Nobody answered immediately. He knew what that silence meant. Someone had broken the route. Mac. Margaret. Restricted legal. One of them. Maybe more than one. Cain sat in the saloon outside the observation centre. The standby Transit was still nearby. His people were waiting for instructions.

He had spent years being the person who closed routes. Jackie’s had opened while he was looking somewhere else. He started the engine.

* * *

Mac ended his own call and stayed at his desk. The safeguarding team had confirmed receipt of the referral. Nothing more. They would not tell him where Jackie was going. Good. Uncomfortable. Good. Margaret called. “It happened.”

“Yes.”

“Cain will know.”

“Yes.”

"You understand this does not erase anything."

Mac looked at the old charity photograph on the shelf. Brian beside him. Years younger. Before Zoe. Before the favour had become a system. "I know."

"You did one thing." "Yes." "Do not confuse it with absolution." "I'm not." Margaret was quiet. Then: "Good." The call ended. Mac turned the photograph face down.

* * *

By late afternoon, Zoe and Elias were in one of the fallback towns. She had asked for the name twenty minutes before they arrived. Elias gave it immediately. No argument. She checked the map herself. Then agreed to continue. Annoying. Functional. Her phone remained quiet until five ten. Then Jackie appeared through Priya's protected relay. Siblings checked. All alive. They won't tell me where. I said okay. Another message: I hate saying okay.

Zoe smiled.

Then:

I told them about Cain. Houses. Legal woman. Phones. Moves. Anything I actually know.

And:

Not your current location because I do not know it.

Then:

Tell her I finally have one useful secret.

Zoe read that one twice.

Elias glanced over.

"What?"

"She finally has one useful secret."

He almost smiled.

"You smiled."

“Unproven.”

“Liar.”

Zoe typed the reply herself.

Keep it.

She sent it.

Then, because some things deserved to remain stupid:

Purple penguin.

Five minutes passed.

Jackie replied.

Still stupid.

Zoe put the phone down.

And for that evening, that was enough.